Department of Education

May 2025

Personal Finance

Primary Career Cluster:	Management & Entrepreneurship
Course Contact:	CTE.Standards@tn.gov
Course Code(s):	G04H36 formerly C29H11
Prerequisite(s):	None
Credit:	1/2
Grade Level:	9-12
Elective Focus - Graduation Requirements:	This course or an approved substitute course is required for graduation.
Program Of Study (POS) Concentrator:	This course does not count toward concentrator status.
Programs of Study Sequence:	This course is an elective in the Banking and Finance program of study.
Aligned Student Organization(s):	Tennessee DECA Tennessee FBLA
Coordinating Work-Based Learning:	Teachers are encouraged to use embedded WBL activities such as informational interviewing, job shadowing, and career mentoring. For information, visit Work-Based Learning webpage.
Tennessee Promoted Student Industry Credentials:	Credentials are aligned with post-secondary and employment opportunities and with the competencies and skills that students acquire through their selected program of study. For a listing of promoted student industry credentials, visit Tennessee Student Industry Credentials webpage.
Teacher Endorsement(s):	024, 030, 031, 032, 033, 034, 035, 036, 037, 038, 039, 041, 050, 051, 052, 054, 055, 056, 057, 130, 152, 153, 154, 158, 201, 202, 203, 204, 311, 424, 430, 431, 432, 433, 434, 435, 436, 450, 471, 472, 474, 475, 476, 952, 953, 958, OR any CTE Professional license with state-approved training.

Required Teacher Training/Certifications:	Please refer to Occupational Educator Licensure Guidance for a full list. Training is only required for those endorsements that are NOT specified. Teachers who do not have the endorsements listed must attend the state-approved training to teach personal finance. Opportunities through UT Extension, the Federal Reserve, and TN Jump$tart are available.
Teacher Resources:	Financial Services Resources Personal Finance Resources

Course at a Glance

CTE courses provide students with an opportunity to develop specific academic, technical, and 21st-century skills necessary to be successful in careers and life. In pursuit of ensuring every student in Tennessee achieves this level of success, we begin with rigorous course standards that feed into intentionally designed programs of study.

Students engage in industry-relevant content through general education integration and experiences such as career and technical student organizations (CTSO) and work-based learning (WBL). Through these experiences, students are immersed with industry-standard content and technology, solve industry-based problems, meaningfully interact with industry professionals, and use/produce industry-specific, informational texts.

Using a Career and Technical Student Organization (CTSO) in Your Classroom

CTSOs are a great resource to put classroom learning into real-life experiences for students through classroom, regional, state, and national competitions, and leadership opportunities. Below are CTSO connections for this course, note this is not an exhaustive list.

- Participate in the CTSO Fall Leadership Conference, DECA and FBLA Fall Leadership Camps, FBLA Regional and State Leadership Conferences, and the DECA Emerging Leader Summit to engage with peers, demonstrate logical thought processes, and develop industry-specific skills that involve teamwork and project management.
- Participate in conferences that promote career development such as DECA Career Pathways and Career Development Conferences.
- Participate in FBLA career competitive events that highlight career development, including developing an electronic career portfolio, interviewing skills, and career exploration.
- Participate in DECA competitive events such as AT&T Later Haters Challenge, Business Finance Series, Financial Consulting, Principles of Finance, Stock Market Game, Personal Financial Literacy, and Financial Literacy Project.
- Participate in FBLA competitive events such as Financial Analysis, Personal Finance, and Securities and Investments.

Using Work-Based Learning (WBL) in Your Classroom

Sustained and coordinated activities that relate to the course content are the key to successful work-based learning. Possible activities for this course include the following. This is not an exhaustive list.

- **Standards 1.1–1.2** | Panel of guest speakers from the financial industry to discuss personal finance—contributing factors, main elements, and value at all stages in life—and assist students as they start to draft their short- and long-term personal financial goals.
- **Standards 2.1–2.2** | Informational interviews with professionals in students' top three careers of interest to discuss education and training paths, career prospects, salary, benefits, necessary industry skills, etc.
- **Standards 2.3–2.5** | Virtual or in-person informational interview with a financial aid counselor at a post-secondary institution to discuss financing post-secondary education, including FAFSA, student loans, alternative funding sources, etc.
- **Standards 4.1–5.2** | Panel of guest speakers from the financial services industry to discuss budgeting, consumer protection laws, available financial services, and how best to use these services.
- **Standard 6.1** | Guest speakers from the financial services industry to develop students' mastery of savings and investments, financial planning, and building a diverse personal investment portfolio.

Course Description

Personal Finance is a foundational course designed to inform students how individual choices directly influence occupational goals, future earning potential, and long-term financial well-being. The standards in this course cover decision-making skills related to goal setting, producing income, budgeting, saving, borrowing, managing risk, and investing. The course helps students meet the growing complexities of personal financial management and consumer decision-making. Upon completion of this course, proficient students will understand how their decisions will impact their future financial well-being.

Course Standards

1. **Financial Responsibility and Personal Decision Making**

    1.1 Personal Finance: **Define** the concept of **personal finance**. Consider how personal finance concepts fit into key life events or stages and explain the importance of personal financial planning using information sources such as instructional materials, news articles, blogs from reputable sources, personal narratives, and industry publications.

    1.2 Goals: Write **short-term** (a year or less), **mid-term** (1 – 5 years), and **long-term** (over 5 years), personal **financial goals** defining desired education, career, and earning milestones, and saving and spending plans. Evaluate factors that may influence the goals, including family responsibilities, individual values, financial factors, and economic conditions.

    1.3 Decision Making: Students will demonstrate the ability to apply **decision-making models** and principles to evaluate **financial choices,** considering factors such as risk, opportunity cost, and personal values, to make informed and responsible financial decisions aligned with their goals.

    1.4 Emerging Technologies: Explore emerging technologies such as **cryptocurrency** and the ethical use of **artificial intelligence** (AI) in personal finance, examining their potential **benefits** and **risks**, and critically evaluating their role in **financial decision-making processes** to make informed choices aligned with ethical principles and long-term financial well-being.

2. **Education, Careers, and Income**

    2.1 Aptitudes, Strengths, and Interests: Complete one or more **career aptitude surveys**, analyze the results, and relate how the identified career aptitudes

align with the student's **strengths and interests**. Evaluate education and training path options to prepare for identified jobs or careers of interest.

2.2 Career Research: Using the **career focus** identified, create an annotated chart, table, or graphic to evaluate the following:
   a. education and training including admission requirements and tuition requirements;
   b. available positions;
   c. salaries;
   d. cost vs. benefits of educational/training;
   e. potential lifetime earning;
   f. employer benefits; and
   g. possible need for relocation to advance.

2.3 Postsecondary Financing: **Explore and evaluate options** for **financing postsecondary education**. Demonstrate an understanding of **Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA)** requirements to apply for postsecondary education financial aid by completing an application. Identify strategies for reducing the overall cost of postsecondary education, including the impact of **scholarships, grants, work-study**, and other assistance and the application process.

2.4 Financing Post-Secondary Education: Explain the **impact borrowing money** to finance different post-secondary options could have on **future financial stability and security**. Research multiple viewpoints that support or question the use of student loan debt in paying for postsecondary education. Assess the extent to which the reasoning and evidence presented support the author's claim. Citing specific textual evidence, craft an argumentative essay that either supports or opposes the use of student loan debt, developing both claim(s) and counterclaim(s) fairly.

2.5 Take Home Pay: Describe **factors affecting take-home pay** such as **tax withholdings, benefits (e.g., insurance, 401k)**, and plan payroll deductions. Complete a 1040 and a W-4 Employee's Withholding Allowance paperwork and analyze the W-2 Wage and Tax Statement for federal income tax purposes.

3. Planning, Housing, and Money Management

3.1 Net Worth: Using money management tools such as online computer-based budgeting tools or hardcopy forms, create a **personal balance sheet**,

determine **assets and liabilities**, and calculate **net worth for an identified career**.

3.2 Monthly Budget: Using research from local sources (e.g., as cost of living calculators, newspapers, chambers of commerce, local government, and company websites), create a **monthly personal budget** that reflects household living expenses, taxes, potential savings, and an emergency fund. Develop a saving/spending plan for a week and track actual spending for comparison.

3.3 Renting a Home: Analyze the **advantages and disadvantages** of renting a home, including factors such as **lease terms**, **rental costs**, and flexibility to make informed decisions about whether renting aligns with their current financial situation and lifestyle preferences.

3.4 Purchasing a Home: Evaluate the process of buying a home, including steps such as saving for a **down payment**, understanding **mortgage options**, and **assessing housing affordability** to make informed decisions about homeownership and its long-term financial implications.

3.5 Consumer Protection: Understand the availability of **consumer protection laws, agencies, and resources**. Investigate the availability and reliability of resources to assist consumers in making **buying decisions**. Include national, state, and local resources, as appropriate.

3.6 Financial Institutions: Research a variety of **financial institutions,** including **banks and credit unions** including digital financial services. Compare and contrast services and products between the institutions such as **checking accounts, savings accounts, certificates of deposits**, etc. Identify one service that best supports the student's personal financial goals and craft an argumentative essay supporting the choice. Using a banking transaction scenario, demonstrate an ability to do the following:

a. reconcile an account both via a traditional register and tracking online transactions;
b. write a check; and
c. verify account accuracy via statements and online access.

4. Credit and Debt

4.1 Consumer Credit: Evaluate the various sources and types of **consumer credit**, such as **student loans, auto loans, store credit cards, flex loans,**

consumer installment loans, title loans, and payday loans. Draw conclusions about the types of credit best suited for financing and/or purchasing various goods and services defending claims with specific textual evidence. Explain how taking on debt early in life may affect financial stability and security later in life.

4.2 Credit Reporting: Examine information from sources such as **major credit reporting agencies**, **federal agencies**, or other credible organizations to describe **credit reports and credit scores**. Describe the relationship between **consumers and credit reports**/credit scores discussing their importance and citing specific textual evidence from research. Analyze a sample credit report and interpret how the contents may affect the credit score. Explain how the **credit score may impact borrowing opportunities** and the **cost of credit**. Summarize specific activities used to maintain a good credit score.

4.3 Cost of Borrowing: Citing evidence found in credit applications, compare and contrast **various types of credit,** and calculate the **real cost of borrowing**. Explain factors that can affect the approval process associated with each type. Identify typical information and procedures required in the **credit application process**. Analyze factors associated with the purchase of an automobile and defend a specific buying decision, including the following:

a. Define and understand factors most often included in negotiations (e.g., as cash vs. financing, inclusion of trade-in, etc.).
b. Evaluate costs and benefits of different service contracts and/or warranty options.
c. Compare and contrast available financing options based on consumer characteristics and the size of the down payment.
d. Discuss the differences in owning vs. leasing a car (e.g., down payment, terms, and contracts).

5. Risk Management

5.1 Insurance: Differentiate the **benefits and costs** associated with **various types of insurance**, such as **health, life, property, and auto**. Describe the risks associated with a lack of appropriate coverage in specific situations. Determine the role of insurance in personal financial planning to preserve and build wealth with financial stability and security.

5.2 Identity Theft: Conduct assessments of various **types of identity theft situations and scams**; then determine strategies and present a plan to

safeguard and protect against identity theft. Design and present a plan to significantly lower and protect against risks. Determine steps that should be taken by a victim of identity theft to report the incident and re-establish identity.

6. Saving and Investing

6.1 Saving and Investing: Explain how **saving and investing** contribute to financial **well-being, building wealth**, and helping meet **personal financial goals**. Compare and contrast **saving and investment strategies**, such as **savings accounts, certificates of deposit, stocks, bonds, mutual funds, employer-sponsored savings plans, physical assets, and commodities**. Design a diversified saving and investment plan that includes strategies compatible with personal goals. Include the time value of money and compound interest calculations in the analysis.